RESEARCH COUNCIL OF ZIMBABWE

Leadership, Innovation and Development

14th ZIMBABWE INTERNATIONAL RESEARCH SYMPOSIUM

CALL FOR NOMINATIONS: RESEARCH AND INNOVATION EXCELLENCE

AWARDS

INTRODUCTION

The Research Council of Zimbabwe (RCZ) hereby invites nominations for the 14th Zimbabwe International Research Symposium (ZIRS) Awards, which will be presented during the Symposium to be held at the Harare International Conference Centre in June 2026. The RCZ hosts the ZIRS on a biennial basis as a premier platform that brings together researchers, policymakers, industry, commerce, and end-users of research outputs from Zimbabwe and beyond.

The ZIRS is an internationally recognised forum dedicated to showcasing cutting-edge scientific research, fostering knowledge exchange, strengthening networks, and promoting strategic partnerships. The ZIRS Awards Ceremony forms a key highlight of the Symposium, providing an opportunity to honour and celebrate excellence in research and innovation across diverse disciplines. At the 14th ZIRS, awards will be conferred in fifteen (15) categories.

Nominations are therefore, invited from individuals, research teams, communities, and companies that have demonstrated outstanding achievement in research and innovation, and have recorded notable success in the application of Research and Development (R&D) or the commercialisation of research outputs within their respective areas of specialisation

14TH ZIRS OBJECTIVES

i. to create an interactive forum for showcasing innovative solutions at the intersection of artificial intelligence, research, and community needs;

ii. to enhance collaboration between researchers, policymakers, and industry leaders for effective implementation of research findings; and
iii. to highlight interdisciplinary approaches that address complex socio-economic issues for national development.

MAIN THEME

The theme for the 14th ZIRS is **"Exploring the Nexus Between Artificial Intelligence, Research, Innovation, and Sustainable Community Development."**

Thematic Areas Guidelines

The Call for Nominations invites submissions aligned to the following key research areas:

1. **Social Sciences, Humanities and Cultural Studies**

   Advancing knowledge on Zimbabwe's social, cultural, economic, historical, and governance systems to strengthen national identity, social cohesion, inclusive development, and evidence-based policy formulation. Research under this theme should contribute to the understanding societal transformation, equity, innovation in governance and sustainable nation-building.

2. **Sustainable Environmental Management and Natural Resource Utilisation**

   Promoting research that enhances the sustainable management, conservation, and value addition of Zimbabwe's land, water, biodiversity, mineral, and energy resources. This theme prioritises climate resilience, environmental protection, disaster risk reduction, and the application of emerging technologies—including geospatial, aerospace, and earth observation systems—to support sustainable development and green growth.

3. **Health, Well-being and Biomedical Sciences**

   Supporting research that improves public health outcomes and strengthens health systems in Zimbabwe. This includes disease prevention and control, nutrition, mental health, indigenous knowledge in health, health technologies, and biomedical innovations aimed at improving the quality of life and achieving universal health coverage**.**

4. **National Security, Peace and Resilience**

   Encouraging research that enhances Zimbabwe's national security, peace, and stability. Focus areas include food security, biosecurity, cyber security, crime prevention, control of invasive pests and diseases, infrastructure protection, border security, and strengthening Zimbabwe's strategic position within the regional and global context.

5. **Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) and Innovation**

Advancing cutting-edge research in Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics that drives industrialisation, digital transformation, innovation, and economic competitiveness. This theme includes artificial intelligence, data science, engineering solutions, manufacturing technologies, renewable energy systems, applied mathematics, and technological innovations that support Vision 2030 and Zimbabwe's transition to a knowledge-based economy.

THE AWARDS CATEGORIES

Category	**Cash Prize $US**
Presidential Awards	
1. Robert Gabriel Mugabe Award to an individual or team for outstanding research	$15 000.00
2. Award to a Female Researcher for outstanding research	$7 500.00
3. Award to a Company / Institute for outstanding application of Research & Development.	$7 500.00
4. Award on outstanding Early Career Researcher	$5 000.00
5. Community Innovation Award	$5 000.00
Sectorial Awards	
1. Social Sciences and Humanities	$3 000.00
2. Health Sciences	$3 000.00
3. Natural and Environmental Sciences	$3 000.00
4. Agricultural Sciences	$3 000.00
5. National Security	$3 000.00
6. Engineering Sciences	$3 000.00
Academic Awards	
1. University Student Research Award	$2 000.00
2. College Student Research Award	$2 000.00
3. Young Scientist – Secondary School (Positions 1,2 and 3)	($1 500.00, $1000 & $500)
4. Young Scientist – Primary School (Positions 1,2 &3)	($1 500.00, $1000 & $500)

NOMINATION GUIDELINES

- The Awards Nomination Form can be accessed on the following RCZ link: https://forms.gle/BKKqjVhgATLUzunW7

  NB: This is available on the RCZ website (www.rcz.ac.zw)

- Complete all sections of the Nomination form. Incomplete Nomination forms will not be considered.
- Nominations in multiple categories are permitted however; each completed form should be used to make a nomination in a single category.
- Attach the supporting documents for the nomination.
- Self-nomination is allowed although not encouraged.
- Nominations entered previously and did not win but have made significant improvements from the last entry may be renominated.
- The nomination must be supported by evidence.
- The nomination must be based on work done in Zimbabwe.

SELECTION CRITERIA

- The nominations submitted will be subjected to a thorough verification and assessment process by a panel of experts and ranked to decide the winning entries for each category.
- Nominees and nominators may be requested to provide evidence and respond to queries relating to the submitted nomination.

DEADLINE FOR SUBMISSION OF NOMINATIONS

- 1600 hours on 20 March 2026

Please kindly direct further enquiries to: awards@rcz.ac.zw

Near-Real-Time Fire Monitoring Dashboard for

Build a web-based dashboard showing active fires (VIIRS/MODIS) and burned area accumulation for the current season.